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I love people-watching on visits to foreign shores, whether it is the morning rush hour commute on the subway, or the hordes of people who stop to grab a sandwich at lunch hour—just regular people going about their business without bothering with some tourists gaping at them. But gape I do, and I see everything from high heels to sneakers, from fitted skirts to pant suits, from suits to jackets to hoodies. But what I don't see enough of anymore are ties.

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It's the same story in corporate India. The tie, that essential bit of clothing for corporate dressing that could take a backseat only on Fridays, when it was considered fine to be casually dressed, is no longer considered a must.

"I have around 50 ties. Some exceptional ones are from brands like Versace and Paul Smith and others are unique and quirky. They all have two things in common—they are beautiful and useless," says Delhi-based banker Aman Khanna. He has been working in the banking industry for over two decades and laments the time when dressing up for work definitely meant adorning one of his precious ties. "Banking has been a conservative industry as far as dressing is concerned, but even that is now changing, with the tie no longer considered compulsory."

There was a time when the tie was a de facto part of everyday dressing. But it has been losing ground for years, between the advent of casual Fridays, the work-from-home (WFH) days of the



IN INDIA, THE RISE OF INDIAN WEAR AT FORMAL OCCASIONS IS ALSO IMPACTING THE WEARING OF TIES

Covid-19 pandemic, and the blurring of lines between our personal and professional lives. The likes of Steve Jobs and Mark Zuckerberg, with their turtlenecks/sweatshirt and jeans, have a role to play in that. Take a look at global movers and shakers from the past couple of decades, and you will find that fewer and fewer have gone fully formal. Virgin Group Founder and billionaire Richard Branson has eschewed ties for years, as have Jeff Bezos and even Bill Gates. Tie-free world leaders include US President Joe Biden, French President Emmanuel Macron, Canadian Prime Minister Justin Trudeau, along with former UK PM Boris Johnson, and the Ital-

ian and Japanese prime ministers, who all abandoned silk ties for the official portrait at the G7 summit in Germany in 2022—marking the first time in 40 years this had happened. Barack Obama set the precedent as President, when he preferred the tie-less-rolled-up-sleeves look at the White House, except for formal occasions.

In the corporate world, even before the WFH days of the pandemic, in 2019, Goldman Sachs, historically known as a white-shoe investment bank, with its bankers in bespoke suits and ties, issued an internal memo relaxing the dress code for all its employees. How significant this move was became